

What gets in the way of reading and writing?

Eight underlying skills that can create barriers to literacy for dyslexic and neurodivergent learners, and what each one can affect.



MEMORY AND PROCESSING

Working and short-term memory

Holding information in mind while you work with it.

CAN AFFECT

Spelling Decoding Building sentences
Comprehension Using several sources
Drafting and editing

Processing speed

How quickly information is taken in, understood and acted on.

CAN AFFECT

Work rate Reading fluency Writing fluency
Comprehension Using several sources
Drafting and editing

WORD-LEVEL PROCESSING

Phonological awareness

Hearing, telling apart and working with the sounds in spoken words.

CAN AFFECT

Decoding Spelling Word reading Reading fluency
Learning new vocabulary

Visual processing

Seeing, remembering and telling apart letters and other visual symbols.

CAN AFFECT

Word recognition Spelling Reading fluency
Letter confusion (b/d, p/q) Automaticity
Keeping your place in text

SELF-MANAGEMENT

Executive function

Planning, organising, staying focused, self-regulating and adapting.

CAN AFFECT

Planning and structuring Drafting
Editing and proofreading Checking for meaning
Comprehension Time and attention

Motor skills and sensory processing

Planning and coordinating movement, and responding to sensory information.

CAN AFFECT

Handwriting Posture Writing fluency
Writing stamina Using writing tools Attention
Self-regulation

LANGUAGE

Vocabulary, grammar and sentence structure

Knowing and using words, grammar and sentence patterns.

CAN AFFECT

Understanding Word choice Sentence structure
Punctuation Tense and grammar

Language comprehension and expression

Understanding and using language in everyday, functional ways.

CAN AFFECT

Comprehension Understanding text types
Expressing ideas The writer's voice

Every learner's profile is different. Most people have a mix of strengths and difficulties across these areas, and a difficulty in one can make others harder. A Learning Needs Assessment builds a clear picture of the individual, so support can target what matters most.

Yorkshire Wolds Dyslexia Service

Learning Needs Assessments · 1:1 literacy intervention
Pocklington, and within about 20 miles

Adapted from an original resource by Louise Selby, Dyslexia Specialist (louiseselbydyslexia.com).

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